

Envelope 10 • Sha'ban • Letters In, Answers Out

Style A2 — Lantern Dawn. Fraunces and Literata. Every word read from source; every drawing from tools/envelope_art.py, which has no figure in it.

Still open where it shows: the fact panel is TO VERIFY and the return address is not set.

ENVELOPE — C5, 229 × 162 MM

NOOR POST

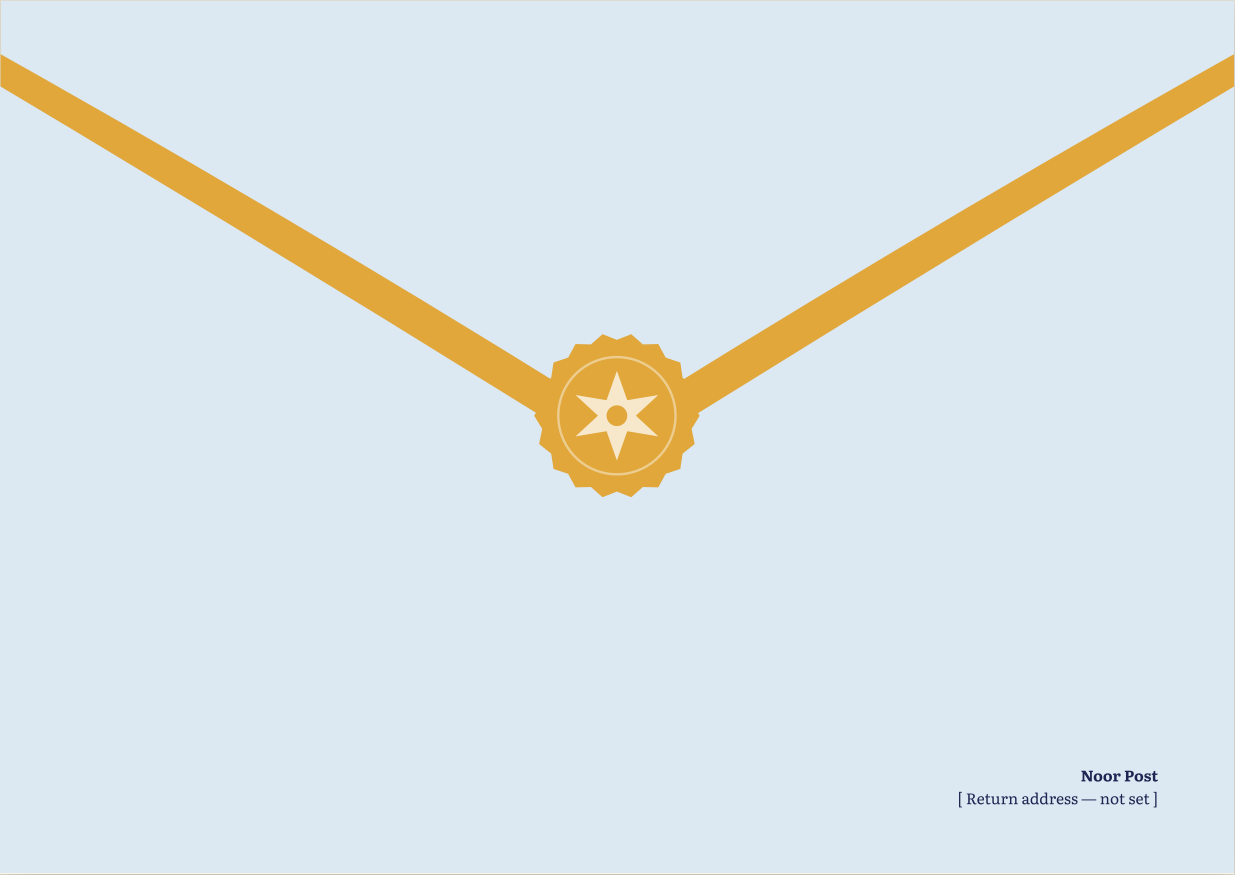
One of fourteen. Open it on the day.



FOR

[Child's name]





Back, with the seal

INSIDE THE FLAP

ENVELOPE 10 • SHA'BAN •
INSIDE THE FLAP

Open together.

🕒 **About twenty-five
minutes**

● is the grown-up. ○ is you.

- 1 The letter — read it out loud, ● and ○ taking turns
- 2 The hadith card
- 3 The prints
- 4 Write one
- 5 The stickers
- 6 The postcard

THE LETTER — ONE A4 SHEET FOLDED TO A5

Imam al-Mahdi

(peace be upon him)

B. 255 AH, SAMARRA

- **Where and when.** Born in Samarra, in the garrison city where his father lived under watch, in a household where the birth was kept quiet from almost everyone.
- **Who was ruling.** The Abbasid caliphs, from Samarra and then Baghdad. The empire that had spent two hundred years keeping track of this family, watching the one house that mattered, and not knowing what was in it.
- **The imamate.** From 260 AH. **Ongoing.** He was about five years old at its start, which is the youngest of the fourteen by some distance.
- **What exists.** The four who carried letters, in order: Uthman ibn Sa'id, then his son Muhammad ibn Uthman, then Husayn ibn Ruh, then Ali ibn Muhammad al-Samarri — each named the next, each known publicly, together spanning about seventy years. And the letters themselves, called *tawq'at*, which survive.
- **Hakima Khatun.** His father's aunt. By most accounts she was in the house on the night he was born, and it is her account that most of what is known comes from. One of the few points in the whole box where the record runs through a woman and could not run any other way.
- **Elsewhere in the world.** In the same years, in England, a king called Alfred was having books carried across from Latin into his own language, because he had worked out that a kingdom where nobody could read was a kingdom that would forget itself.

He has not died. Shia belief holds that he is alive and hidden, and that he will return.

Letters In, Answers Out

• is the grown-up • ◦ is you • ◦◦ is together

- For about seventy years there was an address.

◦ An address?

- Not a house you could visit. A man. You went to him with your question written down, or with money you owed, or with something you needed settled, and you handed it over. And some time later, an answer came back.

◦ From who?

- That is exactly what everybody wanted to know, and the answer was: you do not get to know, and you do not get to go, and the man in front of you is not going to tell you.

◦ Did people trust that?

- Enough of them did. Money went in — real money, from real cities, from people who had worked for it. Questions went in. Answers came out, in writing, and people who knew the handwriting said it was the same hand for a very long time.
- There were four of them, one after another. Not four at once. When the first one was dying, he named the second. When the second was dying, he named the third. And so on. Each one was known by name, in public, and each one did the job for years.

LETTERS IN, ANSWERS OUT · CONTINUED

◦ **How long altogether?**

• About seventy years. Long enough that a person could be born, live a whole life as a merchant or a teacher, and die, with this being simply how things were.

◦ **And then?**

• The fourth one received a letter, and the letter said there would be no fifth. It said not to accept anyone who claimed the job after him. And that was the end of the arrangement.

◦ **Would you have written to him? Say what you would have asked.**

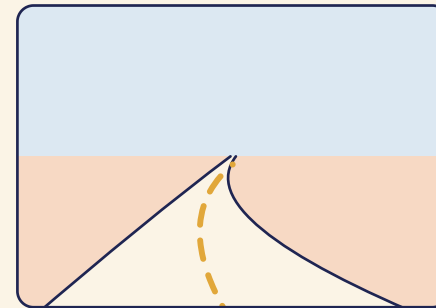
• Nobody has an address now. There is no one to hand a letter to, and there has not been for more than a thousand years, and that is not a gap in the story. That is the story.

• Every other envelope in this box has an ending in it. Somebody is born, somebody lives, and there is a last line. This one does not have one, because it has not happened yet.

SAY THIS ONE TOGETHER

•◦

We are inside this part.



Then the hadith card.

NO SAYING SELECTED

Blocked on a source — nothing prints here until
its row on citation-sheet.md reads V

NO SAYING SELECTED

NOOR POST · THE FOURTEEN

The chain

Every card in this box is one link. Lay all fourteen in order and the chain runs from the Prophet to the last of the twelve, each one passing on what was given.



Fourteen segments · historical order

Blocked: Specified as a tawqi' from the minor occultation. Both Kitab al-Ghayba works are now held with named translators, so this is a reading job — but rule Q3 bans a tawqi' about religious authority, which is most of what survives.



SESSION CARD — OPEN

Write one

No questions this time. No answer card. Nothing to get right.

For seventy years, people wrote things down and handed them over, and did not know when the answer would come, or whether it would come in their lifetime.

Both of you write one. ● writes one. ○ writes one. Not to each other.

Anything. A question. A complaint. Something you want. Something you would only say if you were sure nobody was going to reply this week.

Do not read each other's.

TURN OVER →



WRITE ONE · CONTINUED

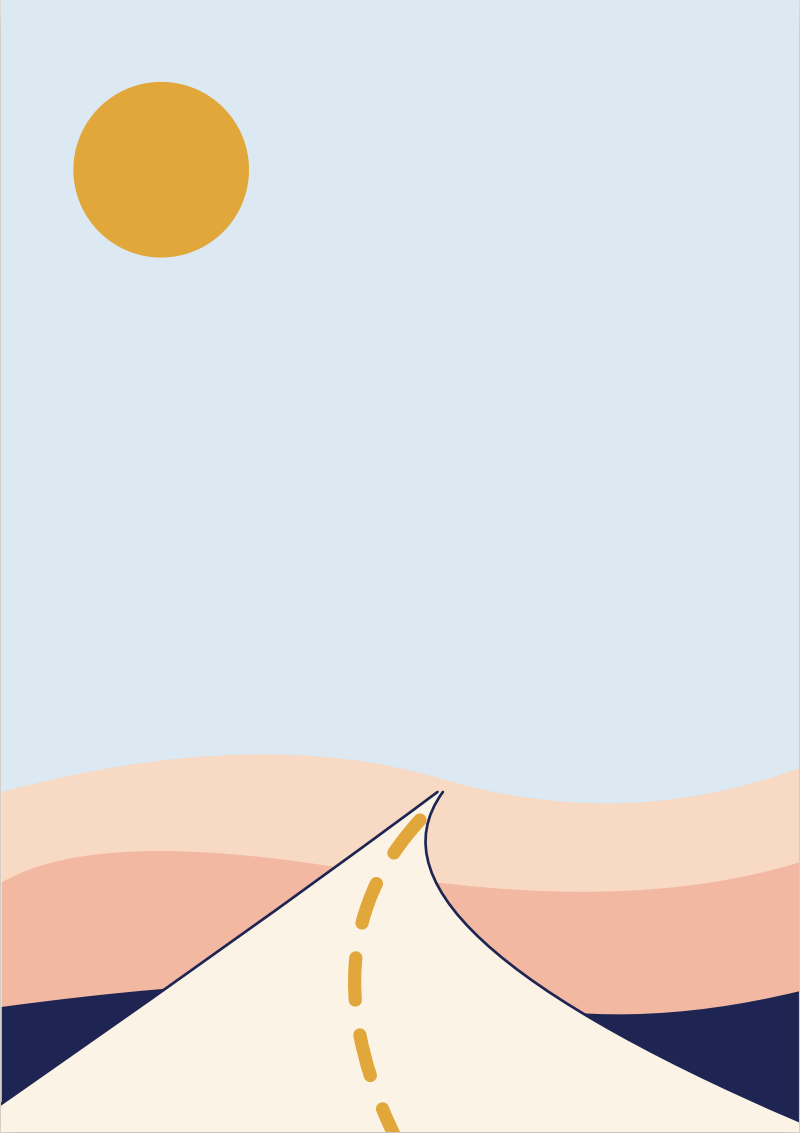
Fold them. Put them in this envelope. Seal it with the sticker.

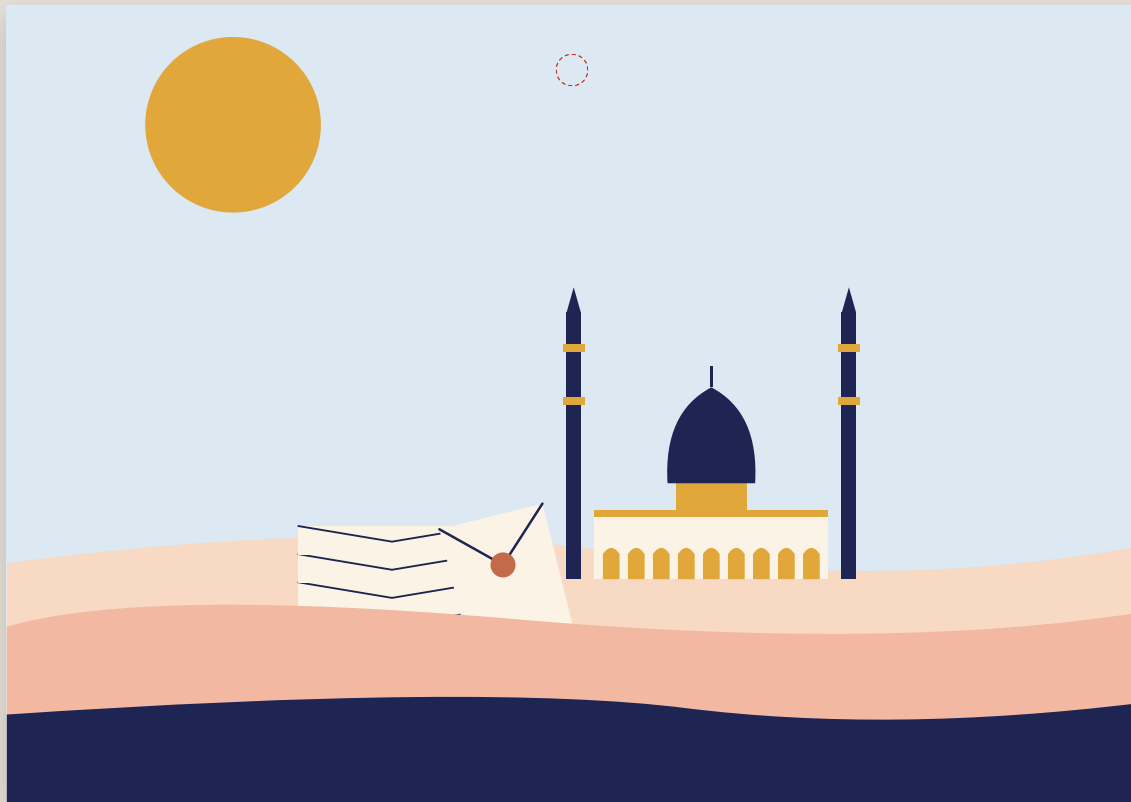
Write next Sha'ban's date on the front.

Then put it away, and do not open it for a year.

That is the *whole* activity. It is meant to feel unfinished.

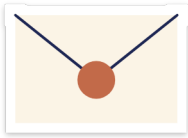
A series of five horizontal stripes in shades of orange, peach, and dark blue, located at the bottom of the page.





Event print — ring position 10. Red dashed circle = punch, screen only

STICKER SHEET — A6, KISS-CUT



RETURN POSTCARD — A6 LANDSCAPE



**We opened this one
together.**

• _____

○ _____

Post it back to us, or keep it. Either is right.



Noor Post

[Return address — not set]
